

APRIL–DECEMBER 1959		1960	1961	1962	1963	1964
MAY 9 North Vietnam establishes Military Transport Group 559 to build a supply route between North and South Vietnam. The route becomes known as the Ho Chi Minh Trail. 		JANUARY 20 John F. Kennedy is inaugurated as 35th president of the United States. JANUARY 28 Kennedy increases funding for South Vietnam to support a counterinsurgency strategy. ☞ Election ticket, 1960.	JUNE 4 At a summit meeting in Vienna, President Kennedy and Soviet Leader Nikita Khrushchev approve a plan for a nuclear test ban. JULY 1 General Maxwell Taylor is appointed as Kennedy's special military advisor on Vietnam.	JANUARY 12 Operation Search Hand begins. American aircraft spray large areas of rural South Vietnam with herbicides, chiefly Agent Orange, to destroy vegetation and deprive guerrillas of cover and food. 	JANUARY 2 Viet Cong ambush South Vietnamese (ARVN) infantry and their American advisors at Ap Bac. It is the first major Viet Cong victory over American-supported troops. MAY 8 South Vietnamese forces shoot and capture a student demonstrator in Hue, leading to widespread anti-Diem protests by Buddhists. South Vietnam is thrown into political crisis.	☞ JFK assassination headline 
☞ Carrying supplies on the Ho Chi Minh Trail 	JANUARY 26 The South Vietnamese 23rd regiment is defeated in an attack by Viet Cong guerrillas at the village of Tring Sup, northwest of Saigon. AUGUST 9 In Laos, Captain Kong Le seizes power in a military coup and denounces American influence in his country. Laos increasingly becomes a focus of Cold War tension between the United States and the Soviet Union.	NOVEMBER 11–12 President Diem survives an attempted military coup led by officers of the South Vietnamese Airborne Division. DECEMBER 12 With the backing of the North Vietnamese guerrillas, the National Liberation Front (NLF) is formed as the political wing of the anti-government insurgency in South Vietnam. MAY 11 Kennedy dispatches 402 Special Forces personnel (Green Berets) to South Vietnam and authorizes covert operations.	 ☞ Green Beret headgear NOVEMBER 22 Kennedy authorizes a major escalation of American involvement in South Vietnam, including the dispatch of military helicopters and armor to fly them into combat.		JUNE 11 In protest at Diem's policies, Buddhist monk Thích Quang Duc burns himself to death in central Saigon, international center of the Dalai Lama regime plummets. NOVEMBER 22 President Kennedy is assassinated in Dallas, Texas. Lyndon B. Johnson is sworn in as president.	JANUARY 30 General Nguyễn Khánh overthrows General Minh in a bloodless coup and takes power in South Vietnam. General Ngô Đình Diệm, South Vietnamese, South Vietnamese is thrown into political crisis. JUNE 20 General Nguyễn Khánh Westmoreland is appointed president to take any action he deems necessary to assist South Vietnam "in defense of its freedom." JULY 1 General Maxwell Taylor is appointed US Ambassador to South Vietnam.
JULY 8 The first American soldiers are killed in South Vietnam in a grenade and on their living quarters at Binh Hoa, near Saigon. ☞ ARVN, used by the NVA and the Viet Cong 				☞ The Strategic Hamlet Program, implemented in 1962 MARCH 19 The South Vietnamese government launches its Strategic Hamlets Program, intended to defend the rural insurgency by protecting peasants from communist influence.	NOVEMBER 2 President Diem is assassinated in the course of a military coup approved by the United States. General Duong Van Minh takes power at the head of a military junta.	JANUARY 20 The North Vietnamese leadership decides in favor of an all-out war to defeat the South Vietnamese government and its American allies. AUGUST 2 In the Tonkin Gulf Incident, the destroyer USS Maddox, on a search intelligence mission, is engaged by North Vietnamese torpedo boats. AUGUST 4 The US Navy mistakenly reports a second naval encounter in the Gulf of Tonkin. AUGUST 5 US aircraft strike targets in North Vietnam in retaliation for the alleged attacks in the Gulf of Tonkin. AUGUST 7 US Congress passes the Tonkin Gulf Resolution authorizing the president to take any action he deems necessary to assist South Vietnam "in defense of its freedom." NOVEMBER 1 Johnson is reelected US president with a landslide victory over Barry Goldwater. NOVEMBER 3 Johnson is reelected US president with a landslide victory over Barry Goldwater. DECEMBER 31 At the year's end, there are 22,500 US troops under attack by the Viet Cong, 1964 ☞ ARVN and US troops under attack by the Viet Cong, 1964 

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